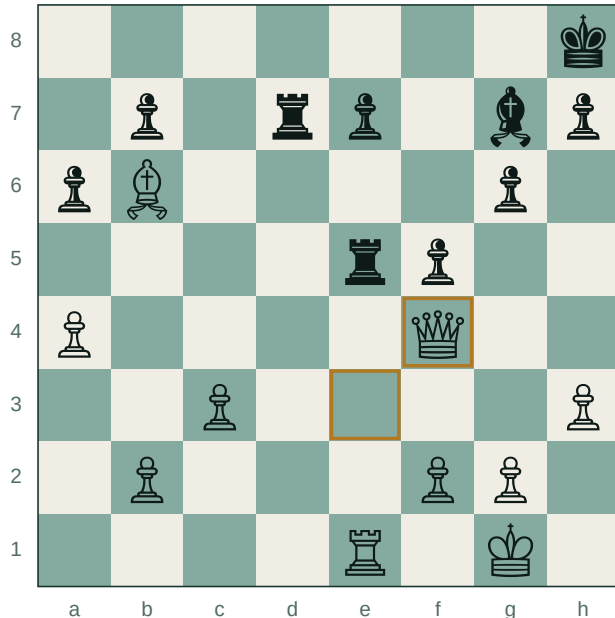


Loose-piece tactics: Black, move 34

Loose-piece tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 34.Qf4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

34...Rxe1+ 35. Kh2 Be5 36. Qxe5+ Rxe5

34...Rxe1+ Check restricts White to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the rook on e1. Recorded reply: **35.Kh2**.

35...Be5 The bishop moves from g7 to e5. Recorded reply: **36.Qxe5+**.

36...Rxe5 The rook captures the queen on e5.

At the end, nominal material is White 9 / Black 16 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +11. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +11:** the balance goes from -4 to +7. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: bishop on b6 and queen on f4. Check for tactical protection.